



SYNONYMS

Different words that mean nearly the same thing

1 What is it?

Synonyms (SIN-uh-nimz)

A synonym is a word that has the same or a very similar meaning to another word. Using synonyms helps writers avoid repeating the same word too often.

different word + same/similar meaning

2 See it in action

Happy

"happy → **joyful, delighted, content, cheerful**"

Said

"said → **replied, whispered, exclaimed, muttered**"

Big

"big → **enormous, huge, massive, vast**"

Bad

"bad → **terrible, awful, dreadful, poor**"



Quick reminder!

Keep a running list of over-used words in your own writing (like 'said' or 'nice') and build a personal bank of synonyms for each.

3 More to know

Scared

"scared → **afraid, terrified, nervous, uneasy**"

Look

"look → **glance, stare, peek, gaze**"

FUN FACT

English has an unusually large number of synonyms compared to many other languages, largely because it absorbed vocabulary from Old English, French and Latin all at once — which is why we have three words for the same idea, like "kingly", "royal" and "regal".

4 Why it's used

Synonyms help: make writing more varied, precise, and interesting — swapping an overused word for a more specific synonym can lift a whole piece of writing.

True perfect synonyms are rare — most synonyms carry a slightly different tone or strength ("annoyed" vs "furious" both mean angry, but at very different levels).



Keep going!

Check the tone of a synonym before you swap it in — 'furious' is much stronger than 'annoyed', even though both mean angry.

5 Don't mix it up

SYNONYMS

Synonyms are different words with similar meanings — "happy" and "joyful".

ANTONYMS

Antonyms are words with opposite meanings — "happy" and "sad".

⚠ Watch out!

Don't swap in a fancy-sounding synonym just because it's longer or more impressive — "said" replaced with "vociferated" for no reason can make writing sound unnatural rather than sophisticated.

6 Quick recap

Similar meaning

Adds variety to writing

Different words, same idea



You got this!

A thesaurus is a great tool, but always check the definition too — not every listed synonym fits every context.